

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS



INDIA-SRI LANKA - 3

MODULE - 29

- 1 Relations between India and Sri Lanka were affected because of the rising Tamil separatist activities and Sri Lankan intervention in the country
- 2 The policies of Sri Lankan President Rajapaksa affected Indo-Sri Lankan bilateral relations.
- 3 He refuses to address the Tamil question and encouraged large Chinese investments in the country.
- 4 On the question of internally displaced persons and war crimes, there is an extremely slow process of rehabilitation of Tamil refugees. India wants Sri Lanka to punish war criminals



FISHERMEN ISSUE

- 1 There is a gradual depletion of fishing resources in the Indian continental shelf; and greater availability of fishes on the Sri Lankan side.
- 2 So, fishermen trespass and indulge into bottom trawling in the Bay of Bengal, Palk Strait and Gulf of Mannar.
- 3 Bottom trawling involves trawlers dragging weighted nets along the sea floor, is known to cause great depletion of fishery resources, and curbing it is in the interest of sustainable fishing.
- 4 It is practiced by Indian fishermen and has emerged as a major issue because of the disruptive impact it left on the coastal communities of Sri Lanka.



FISHERMEN ISSUE

- 5 Sri Lanka regularly arrests Indian fishermen for crossing the International Maritime Boundary Line (IMBL) that demarcates Indian and Sri Lankan waters.
- 6 India and Sri Lanka have agreed to set up a Joint Working Group (JWG) on Fisheries between the Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare of India and Ministry of Fisheries and Aquatic Resources Development of Sri Lanka as the mechanism to help find a permanent solution to the fishermen issue.



FISHERMEN ISSUE

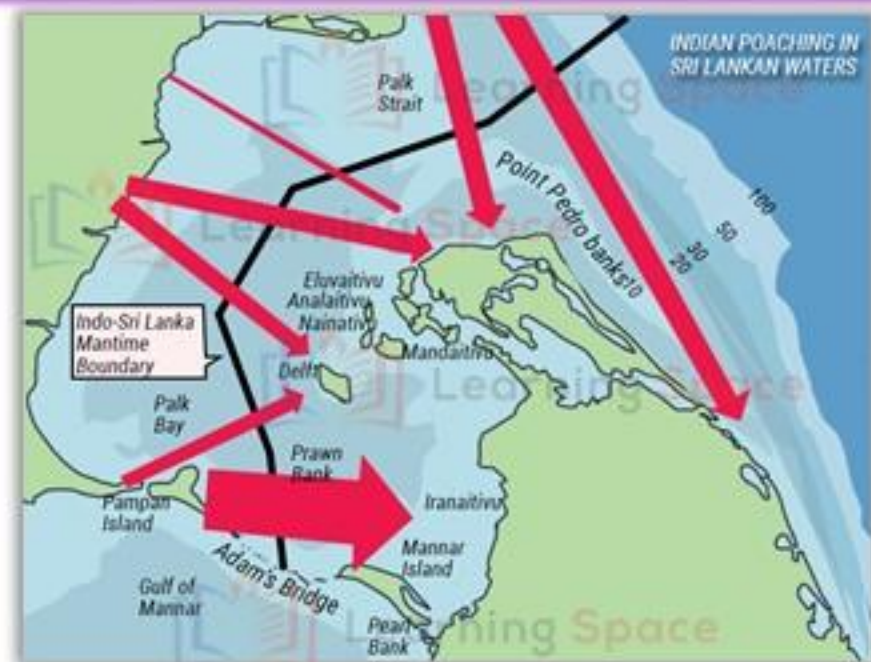
Frequent arrests of fishermen of both countries and seizures of their fishing vessels by the Sri Lankan and Indian authorities in the common sea areas between two countries, affect the relationship.

1 In this scenario, there is a need to provide alternate means of livelihood for them.

2 Unless their dependence on Palk Bay decreases, it will be difficult to curb the natural tendency of Indian fishermen to intrude into Sri Lankan territorial waters.

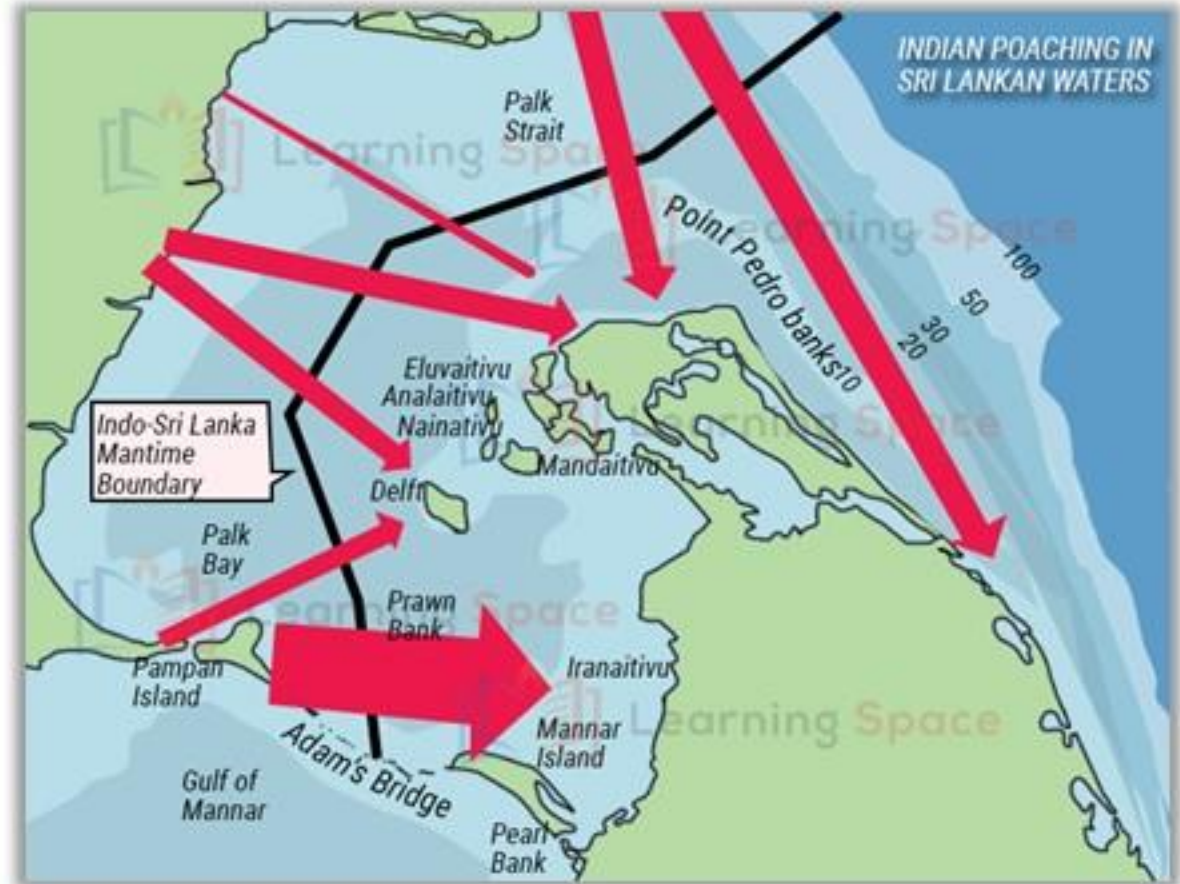
3 There is a need to ensure that fishing is carried out in an organised manner and within an institutional framework.

4 There are economic and environmental effects of bottom trawling.



FISHERMEN ISSUE

- 5 The launch of a program on diversification of bottom trawlers into deep-sea fishing vessels for tuna is proposed under the Blue Revolution.
- 6 This issue can be addressed if local politics is taken care and technology can be used to resolve it.
- 7 There is a growing cooperation between the neighbours with hydrographic surveys of Sri Lanka's Weligama bay provided by the Indian Navy.



CITIZENSHIP BILL

- 1 The Citizenship (Amendment) Bill of India has excluded Sri Lankan refugees from its ambit.
- 2 Most of these refugees reside in the state of Tamil Nadu.
- 3 The bill is restricting citizenship to the non-Muslims of Bangladesh, Pakistan and Afghanistan.
- 4 The refugees from Sri Lanka and Myanmar are eligible for Long Term Visa (LTV) if these refugees had faced oppression in their countries on account of race, religion, sex, nationality, ethnic identity and membership of a social group.
- 5 These visas will provide several facilities to the refugees such as employment in the private sector and pursuing education in India.
- 6 In this regard, India issued a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) in 2011 to protect the interest of such persons



CHINA FACTOR



ECONOMIC

1

In the last few years, Sri Lanka has received billions of dollars of loans from China to build infrastructure projects including highways, a port, airport, convention centre and tallest tower in South Asia among others.



CHINA FACTOR

ii STRATEGIC

- 1 Unable to pay back, Sri Lanka also handed over the strategic port of Hambantota to China on a 99-year lease. This port has a strategic significance in the Belt and Road Initiative.
- 2 However, many Sri Lankan intellectual and policymakers reject the 99 years lease given to China for Hambantota port as 'neo colonial'.
- 3 This threatens India's interests in the Indian Ocean Region (IOR). To cater to India's interests, this port will not be used for military purposes.



CHINA FACTOR

ii STRATEGIC

- 4 In response, India is building the Trincomalee Port.
- 5 India has been collaborating with Japan to develop the East Container Terminal at Colombo Harbor and operate the Mattala port
- 6 Moreover, China has been supplying arms to Sri Lanka since the 1950s
- 7 In late 2014, Chinese naval assets including a warship and submarine, were spotted at Sri Lankan civilian port.



WHY IS INDIA FAILING?

- 1 From Sri Lankan perspective, developing close relations with China as a counter to India make strategic sense.
- 2 Sri Lanka needs capital for development and China is capable enough to support it in its development.
- 3 The interlocutors are of the opinion that China would deliver, but India would be stuck in bureaucratic hurdles.
- 4 Less private sector investment from India is the reason why China has been able to invest in Sri Lanka.



SETHUSUMDARAM PROJECT

- 1 PM Manmohan Singh inaugurated the Sethu Samudram Ship Channel Project.
- 2 It was first proposed by AD Taylor, a Britisher in the Indian Marine in 1860.
- 3 It will involve dredging of a ship channel across the Palk Straits between India and Sri Lanka.
- 4 Two channels were proposed to be created - one across Adam's Bridge (the chain of islets and shallows linking India with Sri Lanka), south-east of Pamban Island and another through the shallows of Palk Bay, deepening the Palk Straits.



SETHUSUMDARAM PROJECT

- 5 The total length of these two channels would be 89 km.
- 6 A special purpose vehicle, Sethusamudram Corporation, has been set up with a debt-equity ratio of 1.5:1 for the Rs 24.27-bn project. The central government will provide Rs 4.95 bn of the equity.
- 7 The Tuticorin Port Trust, the implementing authority, and the Shipping Corporation of India will contribute Rs 500 mn each.
- 8 The project, which envisages a 2.5-km distance between ships moving two ways in the canal, is likely to be a technical marvel.



SETHUSUMDARAM PROJECT

CURRENT CHALLENGES

- 1 At present, ships from the west coast of India to the east coast of India and in Bangladesh, China, etc have to navigate around Sri Lankan coast.
- 2 The existing water way is shallow and not sufficient for the movement of ships.
- 3 This is due to the presence of a shallow region known as Adam's Bridge, located south-east of Rameswaram near Pamban, which connects the Talimannar coast of Sri Lanka.
- 4 Less private Sector Investment from India is the reason why China has been able to invest in Sri Lanka.



SETHUSUMDARAM PROJECT

BENEFITS OF PROJECT

- 1** The Sethusundaram project will reduce the steaming distances between the east and west coasts of India and improve the navigation within territorial waters of India
- 2** Indian coast guard and naval ships will not have to circumnavigate around Sri Lanka
- 3** The channel will cut short sailing of an additional distance of 254-424 nautical miles and 21-36 hours of sailing time.
- 4** Trade will benefit from reduction in maritime transportation cost and save foreign exchange.
- 5** There will be substantial savings for the shipping companies, exporters, importers and manufacturers.
- 6** The channel will become an invaluable asset from national defence and security point of view enabling easier and quicker access between the coasts.



SETHUSUMDARAM PROJECT

BENEFITS OF PROJECT

- 7 Fishermen will directly benefit due to the potential for development of fishing harbours (between Nagapattinam and Tuticorin) with proper landing and storage facilities.
- 8 Maritime trade in Tamil Nadu, both coastal and international, will flourish with rapid development of existing minor port in Ramanathapuram.
- 9 The increasing concern in India about its security requirements, also its growing ambition to be a global super power has propelled to go for the project.
- 10 The greatest beneficiary of the project was envisaged to be Tuticorin Port, which had the long term potential to transform into a container transshipment hub like Singapore and Colombo. The canal project was also expected to foster the development of the proposed 13 minor ports in Tamil Nadu.



SETHUSUMDARAM PROJECT

ISSUES IN THE PROJECT

- 1 Challenge lies to the livelihood of 600,000 people who depend on fishing in the waters where the canal will be dug.
- 2 Local fishermen and environmentalists have opposed the scheme, saying that digging would mean that the seabed scooped from the straits will be dumped in deeper water out to sea.
- 3 This, according to critics, will endanger a rich biosphere reserve with 400 endangered species, including sea turtles, dolphins, dugongs and whales.
- 4 Environmentalists point out that a canal would also destroy the natural barrier between the Bay of Bengal and the shallower, calmer waters of the Palk Bay.
- 5 The Tamil Nadu Pollution Control Board has refused to give the project clearance



SETHUSUMDARAM PROJECT

ISSUES IN THE PROJECT

- 6 Sri Lanka, which was not consulted about the canal and is concerned that the project would disadvantage its port in Colombo
- 7 Coastal Action Network (CAN), an umbrella group of NGOs appealed to the Madras court saying the canal would disrupt their lives.
- 8 In response, the Indian government explained to the Sri Lankan president and her technical advisors that the project was not harmful and they were assured that any new concerns would be addressed
- 9 The Indian government has assured that the Gulf of Mannar biosphere will be unaffected by the canal.



SETHUSUMDARAM PROJECT

P Balasundarampillai, a leading geographer and former Vice Chancellor of the University of Jaffna made the following remarks-

- 1 The ship canal would increase trade to the many small ports on the Tamil Nadu coastline and northern Sri Lankan ports of Mannar, Thalai Mannar, Kankesanthurai (KKS), and Point Pedro.
- 2 According to him, the project doesn't pose any environmental threat.
- 3 According to him, much of the criticism of the project is due to ignorance of new and advanced canal building and dredging technology now available in the world.

- 4 Dredging of the sea is necessary for building and maintaining harbours and this is constantly done with no harm being done to the adjacent coastline.



RECENT STATE VISIT

President Rajapaksa after emerging victorious at the Presidential elections, visited India in 2020.

1 Sri Lanka's former foreign secretary, said the president wants Sri Lanka to remain neutral in its foreign relations and stay out of any conflicts among world powers.

2 He also said that under the new president, the relationship with India will enjoy priority attention.

3 The MEA believed that a stable, secure and prosperous Sri Lanka is not only in India's interest but also in the interest of the entire Indian Ocean Region. It is important for India's "Neighborhood First" policy and SAGAR doctrine.

4 A new \$ 400 million line of credit to Sri Lanka announced which is expected to boost infrastructure and development in Sri Lanka.



RECENT STATE VISIT

- 5 India noted that under the Indian Housing Project, 46,000 houses have been constructed for the internally displaced in the Northern and Eastern Provinces of Sri Lanka.
- 6 India had earlier announced \$ 100 million credit line for solar projects in Sri Lanka
- 7 The countries discussed 20 community development projects and other people-centric projects issued by India in Sri Lanka on the basis of grants in education and infrastructure.



RECENT STATE VISIT

- 8 The countries opposed terrorism in all its forms and also expected action from the international community to address cross-border terrorism.
- 9 Sri Lankan police officers in major Indian institutions were already receiving the counter terrorist training and India announced special Line of Credit of 50 million dollars to Sri Lanka to combat terrorism.
- 10 India hoped that Sri Lanka would work on the process of reconciliation, to fulfil the aspirations of the Tamils for equality, justice, peace and respect.



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